The Project Approach

Traditionally, organisations carry out a large proportion of business change and grow via projects. By definition, these have a beginning and end. They are temporary structures in which teams carry out work with a specific scope, to meet specific business objectives within a specific time. For larger changes a programme structure may be needed in which interdependent changes are made by interdependent projects that achieve their own objective and contribute to a greater suite of objectives which should be met when the whole programme of change is delivered. This approach works well, it allows a separation of project work and business as usual, This in turn allows resource allocation, budgets and timescales to be controlled.

The Project Approach

There are however drawbacks, keeping up with the pace of change can be a major drawback, but is somewhat mitigated by using the agile approach within a project structure, but the second drawback is lack of product focus.

Product Focus

Corporate enterprises deliver products and or services to customers with the aim of adding value to the customer and making profit. Business improvement is therefore based on increasing value by innovation, growth and by producing desirable products and services that meet and hopefully exceed customer expectations. Profits can increase via sustainable growth or by greater efficiency and reduced overheads.

The product approach focuses on these two aspects and allows strategies to be more fluid. Measuring success and analysing market data is key and metrics such as adoption and retention and waste can help companies to achieve this focus whilst balancing cash flows, profits and the financial position.

Product Focus

Innovation, product development and aiming to delight customers is at the forefront of business as usual, not running in parallel or a scheduled activity, but driving everything that an organisation does.

This means that enterprises need to learn continuously so that they know what pleases customers and they know how to gain efficiencies, they can then make continuous judgements as to whether every improvement will add value. Then monitor and ensure that the value is gained. If it is not, this too is valuable, and organisations need to be fluid enough to stop doing things which do not delight their customers as well as continuously looking for new ways of doing things. Enterprises can adopt ways to learn experimentally via empirical methods such as testing the market and accept that some product enhancements will fail. Although failures may be costly, they add to the learning experience and on balance should be outweighed by the successful changes and can be replaced or backed out and written off or enhanced.

Product Focus

Close customer relationships and continuous feedback loops aid this adaptive approach.

The changes cannot be chaotic, otherwise the staff and customers will not keep up with the changes. A product roadmap will still be needed, supported by frequent releases to allow for enhancements. Of course, return on investment needs to be monitored, as well as intangible costs and benefits.

How to Be Agile

Short cycles

Frequent Deliveries

The right amount of work per team

Frequent Feedback

Estimate size of each item to be built (story point)

Estimate how much work can be done by each team in each cycle

(number of story points a team can get done)

Do the work

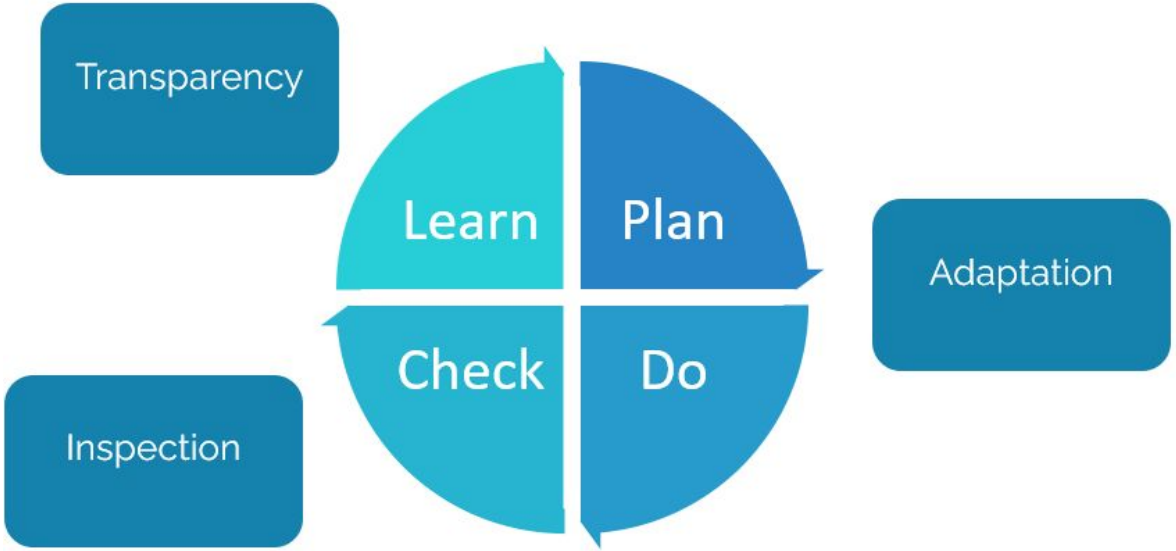
Obtain feedback

Package and deliver the work

Recalibrate to achieve constant velocity

How to Be Agile

Providing visibility to customers and internal stakeholders throughout the cycle. Allows inspection which enables learning and in turn enables adaptation.



Reflection

Agile teams should take time to reflect upon work done and the work that needs to be done.

Progress should be visible and stakeholders (including customers) should be invited to check progress and feedback.

This is often demonstrated by showing working software or prototypes to stakeholders and inviting feedback.

Many Agile frameworks have built in time for reflections, show and tell sessions and inspections.

Work Not Done

- Prioritise features that satisfy the customer
- Delivering value is of the utmost importance
- Less valuable items may be delivered later
- Some may not be delivered at all

Work Not Done

As a caterer

I want to be able to amend orders up to the day before the event

As a business owner

I want a daily report of products sold

As a customer

I want to know that my children are eating healthy snacks

As a customer

I want to choose my own snack, even if the order is placed by my football team

As an accountant

I want to check that all payments are cleared

Simplicity is the Art of Maximising Work Not Done

Challenge what we do

We can also maximise work not done by challenging everything we need to do

It may be okay to cross things of the "to do" list, In fact it feels good.

Guilt Free Shortcuts

Do we have to produce this document?

Do we have to follow this process?

Is there another way to do it that takes less effort?

Servant Leadership

The philosophy that the goal of the leader is to serve. Ideally an agile leader should have been a servant first… and then a leader. This tends to result in a leader who will facilitate the team rather than controlling it. It is essential that the leader allows the team to self-organise. Servant leaders put people first, are skilled communicators, are compassionate collaborators, use foresight and do not use their power to leverage results.

Self-Organising, Cross-functional Teams

Crossing different teams, business areas and skillsets. Team members are usually a specialist in one area, but are generalists in other areas.

Typical skills utilised in an Agile team:

- Analytical
- Architectural
- Business Knowledge
- Software design and development
- Testing

Self-Organising, Cross-functional Teams

Team set up and some standard structures and procedures may be in place.

Team members work together, encourage each other to learn and focus on achieving the teams goals.

They can decide how to approach the work, this tends to lead to increased levels of productivity, higher levels of motivation and faster decision making.

Team Motivation

Autonomy, mastery and purpose are critical factors in creating motivated teams.

Autonomy

- Freedom to direct their own work
- Gives control given to individuals and the team

Mastery

- Allows experts to evolve
- Experimental learning encouraged and mistakes tolerated

Purpose

- The outcomes acheived by the whole team have a higher purpose then individual glory

  Contribution from every individual is valued

Team Motivation

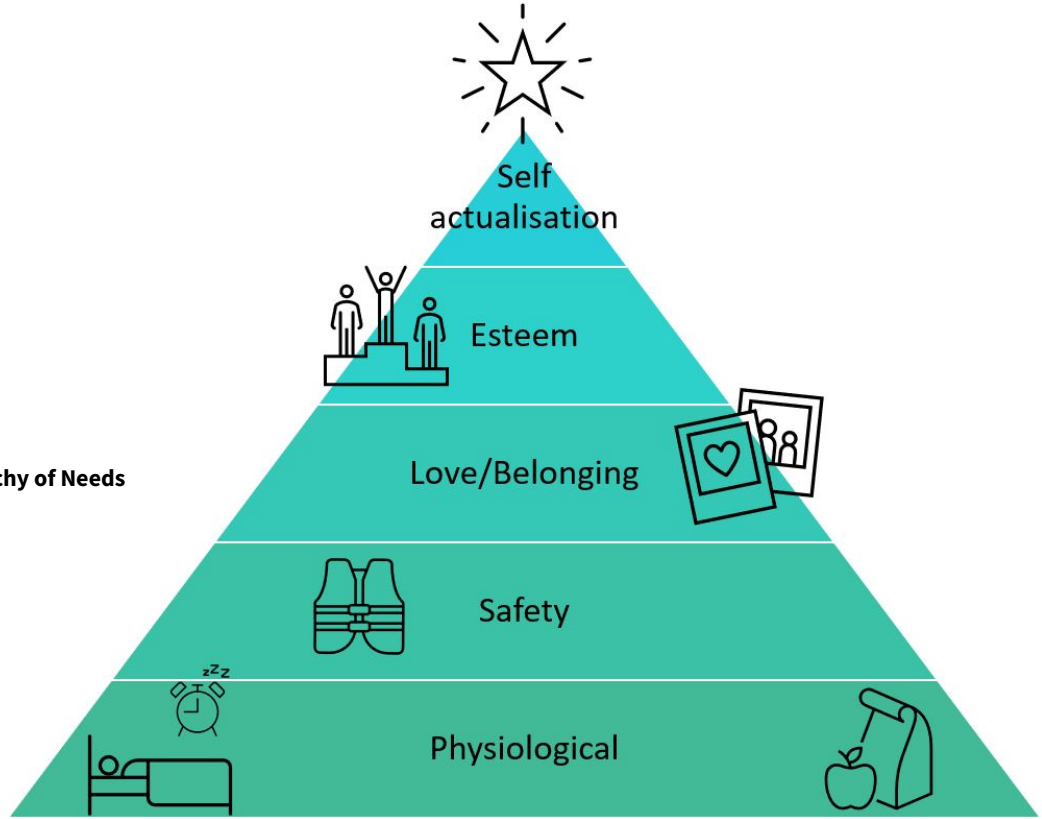
High performing teams need to be psychologically safe. All team members should feel comfortable enough to:

- Give and receive feedback
- Raise concerns
- Challenge
- Seek clarification
- Seek help within the team
- Offer ideas
- Make and admit mistakes

Psychological Safety for High Performing Teams

Teams should be allowed to try new things and not be put off by failure.

Studies have also been carried out into the psychological safety of high performing teams. On the next page is a depiction of Maslow's hierarchy of needs which shows the individual needs that need to be met in order that teams can reach levels of high performance. Psychological safety is critical for supporting teams and helps to reduce fear of failure.

Psychological Safety for High Performing Teams

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs